



PINE Case Study

How an ‘Aha’ Moment Is Transforming Elmira City Schools

A fresh approach to special education is changing how all students learn in an upstate New York school district.

The Elmira City School District’s motto is “Together we succeed.” But despite years of tireless work by its special education and support services professionals, the low-income, upstate New York school district found its special education programs weren’t succeeding — at least not according to the state’s Department of Education.

Dr. Joyce Carr, Elmira’s Supervisor of Special Education and Support Services, explains that the state continuously cited Elmira as needing improvement in different areas at different times, from the reading scores of students with IEPs to their graduation rates. In each instance, the state required Elmira to devise and submit an improvement plan. “It was like playing a game of whack-a-mole,” Carr says. “We were piecemealing together programs to address whatever they targeted us for in any given year.”

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It wasn’t just the state’s findings that pointed to challenges in Elmira’s special education programs. Over the years, Elmira officials had made progress in reducing the number of self-contained classes in the district. Still, they wanted to move even more students into general education classes. Since changes to state education regulations required more disabled and neurodivergent students to take achievement tests in specific subjects — known as Regents exams — to qualify for high school diplomas, that goal had taken on an increased significance. “The kids couldn’t just go to self-contained classes anymore. They had to have access to highly qualified teachers in core subjects,” Carr says.

But many general education teachers and staff didn’t feel prepared to work with neurodivergent students, and some were skeptical that students with these different learning needs could succeed in general education classrooms. Changing such perceptions and encouraging inclusion would require major, systemic changes to Elmira’s approach to special education...but with the right help, the district would prove itself up to the task.



Working With PINE

Elmira school officials turned to the Program for Inclusion and Neurodiversity Education (PINE) to partner on an initiative to empower teachers and staff to provide greater, more effective support to its neurodiverse student communities. They began with a pilot program at four of the district's elementary schools, providing access to PINE's dynamic online learning platform. (See sidebar.)

Carr says that at first, some were wary of the training because they assumed it would concentrate solely on autism. Instead, many found themselves fascinated by the coursework's exploration of neurodiversity and its implications for all different learners. "It isn't just about autism. This is about creating climates and cultures that accept everybody's differences and focus on science and people's strengths, not just their deficits," Carr says. "It was an 'aha!' moment for a lot of people."

Ultimately, 240 Elmira educators completed 1844 hours of coursework in the 2020-2021 school year — a feat made more manageable by the fact that the PINE learning platform is self-paced, offering asynchronous learning. In addition, Elmira administrators included PINE coursework as part of teachers' standard professional development schedules, so they had plenty of options when it came to deciding when and where they'd log in. "They can do it on a Saturday morning with their pajamas on, or they can do it on Wednesday during building professional development time, or they can do it whenever," says Jay Hillman, Elmira's Director of Education Services. "They appreciate that it's flexible."

As any educator knows, learning is half the battle — successfully applying the lessons learned is the other. To help Elmira teachers and staff implement what they learned, PINE set up regular "office hours" — live, online consultations with

Focus on Coursework: What Makes PINE Unique

The PINE Platform features coursework on understanding neurodiversity, creating cultures of inclusion and neuro affirming classrooms, and guides to support professional development planning.

Neurodivergent people, including autistic experts, played pivotal roles in the creation of the courses, sharing insights and firsthand experiences that are often missing from so-called "sage on the stage" presentations common in professional development programs.

The platform was designed for use by all teachers and staff. Lauren Hough Williams, PINE's Executive Director, says PINE aims to engage every person at a school because each has an important role to play in supporting all students. "I want to train the music teacher, the custodian, the recess monitor, and anyone interacting with students," she says. "I want them to feel empowered and have that



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PINE consultants. During these meetings, groups of educators came together to talk with the consultants about specific student challenges and how to address them. The consultants, Hillman says, brought valuable outside perspectives and provided “a forum for some pretty frank conversations about what’s going on in classrooms.”

Pleased with the progress of the four-school pilot program, Elmira administrators decided to expand their PINE collaboration districtwide. In the district’s second year with PINE, teachers and staff at all 11 district schools, including its middle and high schools, were onboarded to the PINE platform and took part in office hours sessions.

sense of responsibility to create a culture of inclusion.”

Dr. Joyce Carr can testify that at the Elmira City School District, the empowerment mindset was real. Rolling out the training to all staff, “was a really refreshing way to do professional development,” she says. “It became just this common learning tool, and we were all rowing the boat together.”

Succeeding Together

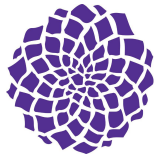
As the Elmira City School District’s work with PINE progressed, the benefits became clear.

“I’m seeing the systemic change I was really targeting. The vocabulary we use. How we speak about the students. How we look at problems,” Carr says. “We’re a kinder organization. We’re more understanding.”

Driving the noticeable shift was PINE’s emphasis on recognizing students’ varying strengths and learning styles, then tailoring educational practices to be more inclusive. Elmira teachers and staff are achieving this with a variety of strategies, such as offering students choices in how they demonstrate understanding of a subject — whether through a standard report, a poem or a painting, for example. On a broader scale, school officials are using asset-based student surveys to discern individual students’ interests and other key characteristics to determine class placements, sometimes grouping students with similar interests together.

Such efforts are engendering more inclusive environments that support not just disabled students, but many other students at the district. “This helps us with all our kids every day,” Hillman says. “We can reach them differently than we did before.”

With more teachers and staff empowered to work with neurodivergent students, Elmira’s number of self-contained classrooms shrank further — down to just three in the 2022-2023 school year. And its graduation rates among disabled students rose, meeting the state benchmark.



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But the Elmira City School District isn't done yet. In their third year working with PINE, officials are aiming to make inclusive practices deeply embedded in every classroom. "We want every kid to feel like they're a member of their educational community, and we want to give them the support to be successful," Carr says. "PINE allows us to give our staff the support they need to meet that challenge."